



RIPHAH
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RIPHAH
DEPARTMENT OF ISLAMIC STUDIES

Characteristics of Islamic Civilization

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Objectives of the lecture

- To recognize the concept of Islamic Civilization
- To know the divine origin of civilization and culture
- To know the foundations of civilization in Islam
- To recognize local and particular cultures and civilizations
- To know about the Universality of Islamic Civilization



Definition of culture and civilization

What is civilization?

The word civilization is derived from the Latin word *civilis*, which means civil. Other related Latin words are *civis*, meaning citizen, and *civitas*, meaning city.

According to Dr. Mustafa Al-Sibai: “Civilization is “a social system that helps man to increase his cultural production.” Civilization consists of the four main elements: economic resources, political systems, moral traditions, and the pursuit of science and arts.”

Mustafa Siba’I, *The Islamic Civilization*, pg:69.



Islamic concept of culture and civilization

A civilization comprises five elements:

1. The concept about worldly life
2. The aim of life
3. The fundamental thoughts and beliefs
4. The training of individuals. What characteristics and qualities does a civilization inculcate and develop in men?
5. The collective system (moral and social life, law, politics, and international relations; and how a civilization manages family, society, and the government.)

Understanding Islamic Civilization, By Sayyid Maududi, Pg: 6.

<https://islamicstudies.info/literature/fundamentals.htm>



The divine origin of civilization and culture

The basic sources of Islamic doctrines consist primarily of the Qur'an and the Sunna of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). To provide for his spiritual, social, and cultural needs, He has raised His prophets from among men and has revealed to them the code of life that can guide man's steps to the right path. This code of life is known as Islam, the religion preached by all of the prophets of Allah.

The Prophet Muhammad (saw) said:

«تَرَكْتُ فِيكُمْ أَمْرَيْنِ لَنْ تَضِلُّوا مَا تَمَسَّكْتُم بِهِمَا: كِتَابَ اللَّهِ وَسُنَّةَ نَبِيِّهِ» مؤطاً الإمام مالك (678)

"I have left two matters with you. As long as you hold to them, you will not go the wrong way. They are the Book of Allah and the Sunna of His Prophet."



Foundations of civilization in Islam

عَنِ ابْنِ عُمَرَ، رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُمَا قَالَ: قَالَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ " بُنِيَ الْإِسْلَامُ عَلَى خَمْسٍ: شَهَادَةِ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا اللَّهُ وَأَنَّ مُحَمَّدًا رَسُولُ اللَّهِ، وَإِقَامَ الصَّلَاةِ، وَإِيتَاءِ الزَّكَاةِ، وَالْحَجِّ، وَصَوْمِ رَمَضَانَ. صحيح البخاري (8).

Ibn ‘Umar reported God's messenger as saying, “Islam is based on five things:

the testimony that there is no god but God and that Muhammad is His servant and messenger, the observance of the prayer, the payment of zakat, the Pilgrimage, and the fast during Ramadan.”



According to the study of Islamic teachings, Islam taught the following beliefs as the core of humanity; they paved the way for a revolution in the world:

1. Monotheism or the belief about One Creator of the universe.
2. The belief of Prophethood.
3. Belief in hereafter
4. The reason for the creation of the universe
5. Man's place in the universe.
6. Man's relationship with his creator
7. Man's relationship to the universe.
8. Human behavior among each other

Understanding Islamic Civilization, By Sayyid Maududi, Pg: 6.

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Universality of Islamic Civilization

Islamic civilization is committed to two basic principles:

- 1: Oneness of Allah Almighty and
- 2: Oneness of humanity.

Islam does not allow any racial, linguistic or ethnic discrimination; it stands for universal humanism. Besides Islam have some peculiar features that distinguish it from other cotemporary civilizations



Universality of Islamic Civilization

Salient features of Islamic civilization

1: It is based on the Islamic faith. It is monotheistic, based on the belief in the oneness of the Almighty Allah, the Creator of this universe. It is characterized by submission to the will of God and service to humankind.

2: Universal dimension: It is not associated with a particular geographic region, race or historical era. Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) said: “All humans are descended from Adam and Eve”. “There is no superiority of an Arab over a non-Arab, or of a non-Arab over an Arab, and no superiority of a white person over a black person or of a black person over a white person, except on the basis of personal piety and righteousness.” Musnad Ahmad (22978)

Mustafa Siba'I, The Islamic Civilization, pg:71,72.



Salient features of Islamic civilization

3: Moral Values: Moral values are of utmost importance in Islamic Civilization e.g., honesty, keeping promises, justice, sacrifice, hospitality, simplicity and equality etc. These traits are the basis of Islamic Lifestyle.

4: Tolerance: Tolerance towards people of different religions is the most important characteristics of Islamic Civilization. This fact is proven through the constitution of Al-Madinah that was built by wisdom of the Prophet Muhammad (p.b.u.h), where Muslims and non-Muslims were dwelling together in harmonious manner, and where the true tolerance, pluralism and peaceful co-existence had prevailed.

5: Integrated and balanced civilization. It insists on equilibrium between the material and the spiritual dimensions of life.

Mustafa Siba'I, The Islamic Civilization, pg:73,76.



Summary

Civilization is “a social system that helps man to increase his cultural production.” Civilization consists of the four main elements: economic resources, political systems, moral traditions, and the pursuit of science and arts.” A civilization comprises five elements: the concept about worldly life, the aim of life, the fundamental thoughts and beliefs and the training of individuals i.e., characteristics and qualities does a civilization inculcate and develop in men. The collective system (moral and social life, law, politics, and international relations; and how a civilization manages family, society, and the government.) The basic sources of Islamic doctrines consist primarily of the Qur’an and the Sunna of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him). Islam does not allow any racial, linguistic or ethnic discrimination; it stands for universal humanism. Besides Islam has some peculiar features that distinguish it from other cotemporary civilizations.



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